CUSTOMER DISCOVERY CANVAS

FROM CUSTOMER PROBLEM TO MEASURABLE BUSINESS VALUE

COMPLETED CANVAS: INVOICE PROCESSING

DISCOVERY → REQUIREMENTS → MVP

CUSTOMER / PROJECT Multinational Finance Shared Services: Enterprise Invoice Processing Efficiency

FDE / TEAM Forward Deployed Engineer (FDE) team

DISCOVERY STAGE Initial (estimates not yet validated)

VERSION 01 Nov 2026 / v0.1

01 CUSTOMER & STAKEHOLDERS

Who owns the problem? Who uses the process? Who makes decisions?

WHO OWNS THE PROBLEM?

F **CFO:** Executive sponsor; raised the efficiency and predictability concern and owns the investment decision.

A **Head of Finance Shared Services / AP Manager:** Operational owner of the 3-business-day SLA (name and role to confirm).

WHO USES THE PROCESS?

F **AP processors (~60–65):** Receive, verify, resolve discrepancies, route approvals, post in SAP, track status.

F **Procurement teams & business owners:** Own POs, goods receipt / service confirmation and approvals; key responders on discrepancies.

F **Suppliers (10,000–11,500):** Submit invoices by email / e-docs / procurement systems; chase status and payment dates.

WHO MAKES OR INFLUENCES DECISIONS?

F CFO decides direction and budget; Technology team has proposed AI (influencer, not decision maker).

A SAP/IT owner, Treasury (payment runs), Tax, Internal Audit / Controls must sign off on any change.

U Who has authority to change approval policy, PO/tolerance rules and supplier submission standards?

02 BUSINESS OBJECTIVE

Why change? What triggered the request? What matters most?

WHY CHANGE?

F Despite SAP, teams spend significant time checking invoices, resolving discrepancies and communicating with suppliers.

F Leadership concerns: processing delays, operating overhead, poor visibility and an inconsistent supplier experience.

WHAT TRIGGERED THE REQUEST?

F CFO concern over efficiency and predictability; month-end is “particularly stressful” (~65% of invoices arrive late in the month).

F Technology team suggested AI; CFO wants the real problems and business value understood before buying another platform.

WHAT MATTERS MOST?

F Suppliers paid on time, less unnecessary manual effort, predictable performance against the 3-day SLA.

A Relative priority of cost vs. SLA vs. supplier experience is not stated; CFO to rank.

D Solution-agnostic: process change, SAP workflow, conventional automation and/or AI. Choice must be justified by discovery evidence.

03 EXPECTED OUTCOMES

What should improve? How will we measure success?

WHAT SHOULD IMPROVE → HOW WE MEASURE IT

F **Faster turnaround:** Average and P90 cycle time, receipt → SAP posting (business days).

F **SLA compliance:** % of invoices processed within 3 business days, by stage, entity and supplier.

F **Fewer avoidable exceptions:** Exception rate % by root cause; first-pass (touchless) match rate.

F **Less repetitive manual work:** Touches and handling minutes per invoice; invoices per FTE per month.

F **Visibility:** Live backlog by status and age (awaiting validation, clarification, approval, payment).

F **Lower month-end pressure:** Peak backlog, overtime hours, days to clear month-end queue.

F **Supplier predictability:** Status inquiries per month; on-time payment %.

F **Measurable financial benefit:** Cost per invoice, capacity released (FTE), late-payment / discount impact.

A Numeric targets (e.g. SLA ≥ 90%) are not set; agree them with the CFO once the baseline is measured.

04 CURRENT PROCESS / AS-IS

What happens from request to closure? Where are handoffs?

FROM RECEIPT TO CLOSURE

F **1 Receive:** Multi-channel intake: email, electronic documents, procurement systems.

F **2 Identify supplier:** Verify supplier details against the vendor record.

F **3 Extract data:** Invoice no., date, amount, tax, PO reference (largely manual).

F **4–5 Match:** Check against approved PO, then goods receipt / service confirmation where applicable.

F **6 Detect discrepancies:** Quantity, price, tax, supplier data, supporting documents.

F **7 Resolve:** Email back-and-forth with suppliers, procurement and business owners. Wait time sits here.

F **8–9 Approve & post:** Route for approval; record and process in SAP.

F **10 Track & communicate:** Unresolved invoices and payment status tracked in Excel and email.

HANDOFFS

F Supplier → AP (intake) · AP ↔ Procurement / business owner (GR, discrepancy) · AP → Approver · AP → payment run · AP → Supplier (status).

U Where the SLA clock starts and stops; PO vs non-PO split; touchless %; time and wait per step.

05 CORE PROBLEM & PAIN POINTS

What is going wrong? Which findings are verified?

WORKING PROBLEM STATEMENT

A Invoices do not flow predictably within the 3-day SLA because exceptions are resolved through manual, email-driven handoffs with no shared visibility, and nobody yet knows where the delay sits or why.

WHAT IS GOING WRONG (CUSTOMER-REPORTED)

F **Delays:** Some invoices exceed the 3-day SLA; the stages responsible are not established.

F **Manual verification:** Invoices compared by hand with POs, supplier records and documents; time not measured.

F **Exceptions:** Incomplete info, wrong supplier references, amount mismatches, missing documents.

F **Month-end peak:** ~65% of invoices arrive late in the month; cause (capacity, process, supplier behaviour, systems) unknown.

F **Low visibility:** Status lives in Excel and email; reporting may not support operational decisions.

F **Supplier chasing:** Suppliers contact AP about status and payment dates.

WHICH FINDINGS ARE VERIFIED?

U None are quantified yet. All six are customer statements; frequency, root cause and impact need SAP and mailbox evidence.

06 BUSINESS IMPACT & BASELINE

How often? What cost, time, risk or rework results?

SCALE (CUSTOMER ESTIMATES)

F ~25,000 invoices / month (~300,000 / year); ~US$5B annual spend; 10,000–11,500 active suppliers.

F ~60–65 AP staff; 3-business-day target SLA; ~65% of volume arrives toward month-end.

A ≈ 385–415 invoices per FTE per month (~19 per working day); ≈ 16,000 invoices in the month-end window.

A ≈ US$415M of supplier spend passes through AP each month; delays hit cash forecasting, supplier trust, discounts and late fees.

COST, TIME, RISK, REWORK: BASELINE STILL UNKNOWN

U Cycle time and SLA attainment %; exception rate and rework loops per invoice; cost per invoice.

U Supplier inquiry volume and handling time; late-payment penalties; missed early-payment discounts.

U Month-end overtime and backlog carried over; duplicate or erroneous payments.

A **Risks:** Tax/compliance errors, audit findings, supplier dissatisfaction, staff fatigue at month-end.

F All figures are initial estimates; their accuracy and definitions must be validated before any business case.

07 DATA, SYSTEMS & CONSTRAINTS

What systems, data, rules and dependencies exist?

SYSTEMS

F **SAP:** System of record for POs, goods receipts, vendor master, invoice posting and payments.

F **Email, Excel trackers, document repositories, procurement systems:** Intake, discrepancy resolution and status tracking.

U SAP module/version, workflow and approval configuration; any OCR or e-invoicing already in place.

DATA NEEDED FOR DISCOVERY

A Invoice lifecycle timestamps (receipt → post → pay), block / exception reason codes, PO and GR data, vendor master quality, AP mailbox volumes, Excel trackers, supplier inquiry logs.

A Timestamps for manual steps outside SAP (email, Excel) are probably missing and will need sampling.

RULES & DEPENDENCIES

A PO matching (2/3-way) and tolerances, delegation-of-authority approval matrix, country tax rules, payment terms and run calendar.

F Dependent on procurement and business owners for confirmations and approvals.

CONSTRAINTS

A Multi-country (tax, language, e-invoicing mandates), data privacy, segregation of duties and audit controls, month-end change freeze.

F No new platform without proven value; no solution approved yet.

08 REQUIREMENTS & MVP OPTIONS

What capabilities could help? What is the smallest useful pilot?

CAPABILITIES THAT COULD HELP (HYPOTHESES UNTIL VALIDATED)

A **Process:** Mandatory PO reference, standard invoice content, single intake channel / supplier portal, supplier cut-offs to flatten month-end.

A **SAP enhancements:** Match tolerances, auto-matching, blocked/parked invoice workflow, approval reminders and escalation.

A **Conventional automation:** OCR / document capture, rule-based vendor checks, AP aging and status dashboard.

A **AI-assisted:** Extraction and classification of unstructured invoices, exception triage with suggested resolution, supplier status self-service.

SMALLEST USEFUL PILOT

D **Step 0 (2–4 weeks):** Process-mining baseline of 3 months of SAP + mailbox data to locate delays and exceptions.

D **Pilot:** One high-volume entity or top-50 suppliers: exception triage + live aging dashboard, measured against baseline SLA and touches per invoice.

NON-FUNCTIONAL REQUIREMENTS

A Integrates with SAP, keeps human approval and an audit trail, no disruption at month-end.

09 VALIDATION & NEXT STEPS

What must be confirmed? Who owns each decision?

WHAT MUST BE CONFIRMED (OWNER)

U Validate the estimates and definitions, e.g. what “processed” means for the SLA (AP Manager + FDE).

U Extract SAP invoice lifecycle data: timestamps, block reasons, PO/GR links (SAP / IT lead).

U Sample 300–500 exceptions to size types and root causes (FDE + AP team leads).

U Month-end driver: arrival pattern vs capacity vs supplier behaviour (FDE + Procurement).

U Supplier inquiry volume, channel and handling time (AP helpdesk).

U Shadow processors at 2–3 sites to time each step and handoff (FDE).

DECISIONS & OWNERS

D **Success metrics and targets:** CFO.

D **Pilot scope and go / no-go on technology investment:** CFO + Head of Finance SSC + IT.

D **Policy changes (supplier rules, tolerances, approvals):** Financial Controller + Head of Procurement.

NEXT STEPS

D Week 1: stakeholder interviews and data request · Weeks 2–3: baseline analysis · Week 4: findings and value readout to CFO.